

The Captive

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

They found him in the ditch at the field's eastern edge, half-buried in mud, moving with the determined slowness of someone who had decided that dying in a ditch was preferable to dying on his feet but hadn't entirely given up on a third option.

He was a dwarf. Broad, grey-bearded, armour cracked along the left pauldron where something had hit him hard enough to leave a dent the size of a fist. His helmet was gone. One hand was pressed against his side with the practised pressure of a man who had been doing it long enough to know exactly how much it helped, which was not much.

He looked up when Blackhoof's shadow fell across him.

He said something in Dwarfish.

"No," said Briggs.

The dwarf said something else.

"Still no," said Briggs. He looked at the dwarf the way he looked at most problems — with the flat assessment of a man calculating the shortest distance between the current situation and his evening meal. He drew his sword with the unhurried ease of someone performing a familiar task.

"Wait—" Blackhoof said.

"He's wounded, enemy, and I'm hungry." Briggs crouched to get a better angle. "This is the most efficient solution."

"You can't just—"

"I can, actually. It's quite straightforward." He tilted his head slightly. "You can look away if you'd like."

Blackhoof stepped forward and put himself between Briggs and the dwarf, which given the difference in their respective sizes created a fairly comprehensive obstacle.

Briggs looked up at him.

"Move," he said.

"He's wounded and unarmed." Centaur didn't move an inch.

"Correct on both counts. That's rather the point."

"He should be taken to camp." Blackhoof kept his voice level with the effort of someone who had been practising. "He could have information. He could be—"

"He could be a problem that resolves itself cleanly in the next thirty seconds." Briggs stood. "Which is considerably more than most problems offer." He gestured with the sword. "You're in the way."

They looked at each other.

"Blackhoof." Briggs's voice carried the particular flatness that meant he was approaching the end of his patience, which in Briggs's case was a journey that had never been particularly long.

"We are on the edge of a battlefield. We have a wounded enemy combatant and approximately two hours of daylight. I have paperwork, a flask that needs refilling, and absolutely no interest in escorting a dwarf over a hill. Stand aside, that's an order!"

"Yes, sergeant!" Blackhoof said with teeth closed tight. "Good horse follows orders!"

Briggs said nothing. Blackhoof knew very well how his last sentence stings. The silence followed had edges.

Briggs looked at him for a long moment with an expression that Blackhoof couldn't entirely read — something moving behind the flatness that wasn't quite anger and wasn't quite anything else. Then he put the sword away with the precise, deliberate movement of a man making a decision he hadn't entirely finished making.

Blackhoof turned to the dwarf in the ditch, shaking his head in an internationally negative gesture. *I did what I could, sorry.*

The dwarf looked at him warily.

Then a spark came across his eyes. He pointed to himself: "Blackhoof!" Then he pointed at the dwarf, with the questioning expression of someone asking a very simple question.

The dwarf understood. He straightened slightly, with the dignity of a man who had decided that if this was how it ended, he would at least end it correctly.

"Hamring," he said. "Hamring Oreseeker."

Behind Blackhoof, something happened to the air.

It was not a sound. Briggs made no sound. But there was a quality of stillness that had not been there a moment before — the specific stillness of a man who had been about to do something and had, without entirely meaning to, stopped.

Blackhoof kept his face carefully neutral.

"Hamring," he repeated, and nodded, and stood. He turned back to Briggs.

Briggs was looking at the dwarf. At Hamring Oreseeker, grey-bearded and mud-covered and pressing his hand against his side in the ditch, who had a name now, which was an inconvenient thing for him to have.

"I know what you did," Briggs said, without looking at Blackhoof.

"I just asked his name."

"Yes." A pause. "I know what you did."

Blackhoof said nothing and attempted, with incomplete success, to arrange his expression into something that was not satisfaction.

"Don't," Briggs said, still not looking at him.

"I'm not doing anything."

"Your face does."

"My face is doing nothing."

"Your face," said Briggs, picking up Hamring's unresisting arm and pulling it over his shoulder with the resigned efficiency of a man who has lost an argument he hadn't intended to enter, "is insufferable. Get his other side."

The hill was longer than it looked.

Hamring Oreseeker was solid in the way dwarves were solid — built for endurance rather than speed, heavy with the particular density of someone who had spent decades underground arguing with rock. He bore his wound without complaint, which Briggs acknowledged internally and did not mention aloud.

They crested the hill in the last of the afternoon light, the camp spread below them in the shallow valley — fires lit, the orderly chaos of an army settling in for the evening. Blackhoof could feel Briggs's mood radiating beside him like a low heat: not explosive, not sharp, but steady and persistent, the warmth of a man who had been maneuvered into something and knew it and had not yet decided what to do about knowing it.

He really was trying not to look pleased with himself.

He was not entirely succeeding.

"Blackhoof," Briggs said, as they started down the slope.

"Sergeant."

"Whatever expression you're currently wearing—"

"I'm not wearing any expression."

"—I want you to remove it before we reach the gate."

"My face is completely neutral."

"Your face," said Briggs, "has never been neutral in its life."

Hamring said something that sounded, improbably, like agreement.

Commander Gord was a practical goblin, which was why he had risen lower rank to field commander after Tusk's spectacular fall from grace, and why he had developed the particular skill of identifying value in unexpected places. He stood in the centre of the command tent with his arms crossed and looked at the mud-covered dwarf between his two soldiers for a long moment.

Then he looked again.



He uncrossed his arms.

"Where," he said carefully, "did you find this man."

"Eastern ditch," Briggs said. "Field's edge. He was attempting to withdraw."

"Did he." it was not a question.

Briggs looked at the armour. He had looked at it before, of course — had noted the quality of it, the weight of it, the craftsmanship of the remaining intact sections. He had attributed it to a well-equipped soldier. He revisited this assessment now, with the specific sensation of a man realising he has been sitting on something important.

Gord let out a long breath. "Sergeant Briggs. You have brought me Hamring Oreseeker, High Commander of the Deepstone Dwarven Brigade, ranking officer of the eastern alliance, and the single most valuable captive this army has taken in three years of campaign." He paused. "Alive."

Silence.

Briggs said nothing.

Blackhoof said nothing, but it was a more active nothing — the nothing of a creature becoming very still.

"The information this man carries," Gord continued, warming to his subject, "could shorten this war by months. The ransom alone would fund the next campaign." He shook his head with the wondering expression of a man reassessing his afternoon. "Sergeant, this is—this is extraordinary work."

"Thank you, sir," said Briggs, in a tone that committed to nothing.

Gord was already moving, calling for his adjutant with one hand and reaching for his decoration box with the other — a flat wooden case that lived on his campaign table and was opened rarely enough to retain a certain ceremony. He produced a medal on a dark ribbon, the highest field commendation in the goblin army's gift, and pinned it to Briggs's chest with the solemn efficiency of a man who had done this before and knew its weight.

Briggs stood at attention and stared at the middle distance.

Gord stepped back, looked at both of them, and smiled the smile of a commander for whom the afternoon had resolved satisfactorily. His eyes moved to Blackhoof with genuine warmth — the uncomplicated warmth of a man who was about to do something generous and knew it.

"And for the mount," he said, reaching back into the case, "the Crimson Commendation. Highest honour we can give a war beast." He produced a length of deep red ribbon, thick and braided, and moved to Blackhoof's side with the purposeful air of a man performing an act of distinction.

He fastened it to the saddle strapping.

Carefully. Correctly. With the full ceremony the moment deserved.

He stepped back and looked at his work with satisfaction.

Blackhoof looked down at the ribbon on his harness.

He looked at Briggs's medal on Briggs's chest.

He looked at Gord, who was beaming at him with the uncomplicated pleasure of a man who had rewarded excellence in all its forms and felt good about it.

"Finest piece of cavalry instinct I've seen this campaign," Gord said warmly. "You should be proud."

Blackhoof said nothing, his face suddenly completely empty.

His jaw was doing something precise and controlled that had nothing to do with speaking.

Gord clapped Briggs on the shoulder, issued three rapid orders to his adjutant regarding the prisoner's accommodation and medical attention, and swept out of the tent with the energy of a man whose evening had improved considerably.

The tent flap settled behind him.

In the quiet that followed, Briggs looked at the ribbon on the saddle strapping. He looked at it for a measured moment, with the expression of a man deciding how much rope to extend and in which direction.

Then he looked up at Blackhoof's face.

"Don't," said Blackhoof, very quietly.

"What?" Gnomes beard found a very interesting shape, almost like it would hide a smile.

"You were about to say something."

"I was going to say," Briggs said, with the careful precision of a man placing each word exactly where he intended it, "welcome back to solid ground."

The silence stretched.

"The ribbon," Blackhoof said finally, "is on my harness."

"Yes."

"The harness. That the saddle sits on."

"I noticed."

"He put my commendation on the saddle strapping." His voice was admirably level. "Like a rosette on a prize stallion."

"To be fair," Briggs said, "it is a very distinguished piece of strapping."

Blackhoof turned and looked at him with an expression that had moved some distance past irritation and was surveying the landscape beyond.

Briggs met the look without flinching, which was either courage or the very precise deployment of a straight face, and said nothing further, because some victories were better left unmarked.